

software, but it also eats up a large amount of disk space.

As the default setting, System Restore reserves a huge 12 per cent of each drive for itself. You can reduce this amount by cutting back on the number of restore points the utility sets for itself. You can also turn off the feature if you wish to.

To adjust the System Restore settings, right-click 'My Computer' and select 'Properties'. Choose the 'System Restore' tab.

To disable System Restore, simply check the 'Turn off system restore on all drives' box. Otherwise, highlight a drive and click 'Settings.'

Using the slider, you can set how much space on the drive System Restore will use for its restore points.

Decreasing this number will limit some of your flexibility in restoring your system should it be necessary, but reducing the amount down to about five per cent should still be safe enough for anyone with an 80 GB hard drive.

Click 'OK' when you're done. Remember to choose 5 per cent if you're unsure.

Delete Unwanted Screensavers

Windows XP comes bundled with a number of annoying and/or useless screensavers. There's no menu that helps delete them.

To delete these, go to C:\Windows\System32\dllicache. This is a hidden folder, so you'll need to type the name

Bet You Didn't Know

Cleaning Out The Prefetch Folder

XP uses a system called 'prefetching' to organise and preload some of the data necessary for commonly-used applications and files.

A folder called 'Prefetch' is used to store the information XP needs to carry out this operation. After several months, the 'Prefetch' folder may become overloaded with references to files longer in use.

It's a good idea to manually empty the older files out of the 'Prefetch' folder every few months or so. To do this, go to 'C:\Windows\Prefetch' and delete all the .PF files that are older than a week or two.

out in the address bar, or 'run' it from the Start Menu. Once there, delete the screensavers you want to discard. (If you have lots of files in this folder, you can locate screensavers by looking for .scr files.)

Note that deleting these files from the System32 folder does not help—they will reappear!

Altering The Page File

Page files are one or more areas of your hard disks that XP reserves for virtual memory. Put simply, these reserved areas are used to contain data that may spill over from main memory.

Virtual memory is

accessed by Windows just like physical memory, but is many times slower because of the much slower speed of hard drive data transfer as compared to RAM.

XP actually uses the page files continuously, regardless of the amount of free memory on your system, so optimising these files can have a positive effect on your computer's performance.

To optimise the page file(s), the following are a few options you can consider:

The NTFS File System

The NTFS file system, introduced with first version of Windows NT, is a completely different file system from FAT. It provides for greatly increased security, file-by-file compression, quotas, and even encryption. It is the default file system for new installations of Windows XP, and if you're doing an upgrade from a previous version of Windows, you'll be asked if you want to convert your existing file systems to NTFS.

Page File Placement

Since page files require disk access to write and retrieve information, putting them on the same drive as the operating system can compromise the performance of both.

Since most systems contain only a single hard drive, this is not usually something that can be changed. But if your system has more than one hard disk, consider placing the page file on the non-OS disk and

removing the one on the disk that has the OS.

To do this, right-click 'My Computer' and select 'Properties', then the 'Advanced' tab. In the 'Performance' section, click 'Settings', then select the 'Advanced' tab. In the 'Virtual Memory' section, click 'Change.' From here, you can choose individual drives and customise the size of the page files you wish to create.

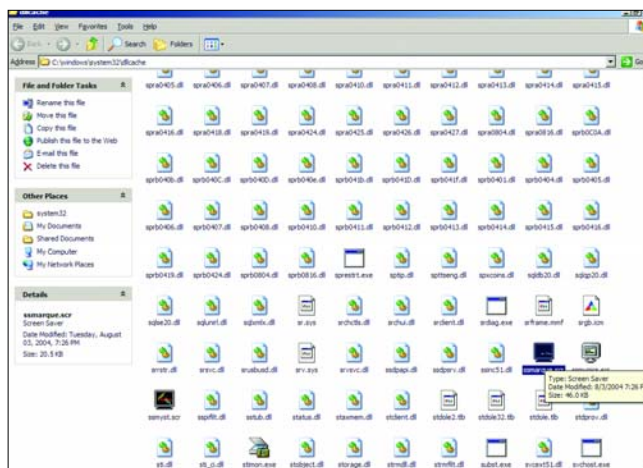
Set Priorities For Individual Programs

If you regularly multitask while working with some applications requiring more memory than others to work effectively (for example, using Photoshop along with Word or other less demanding programs), you may consider setting custom priorities for applications that use more memory.

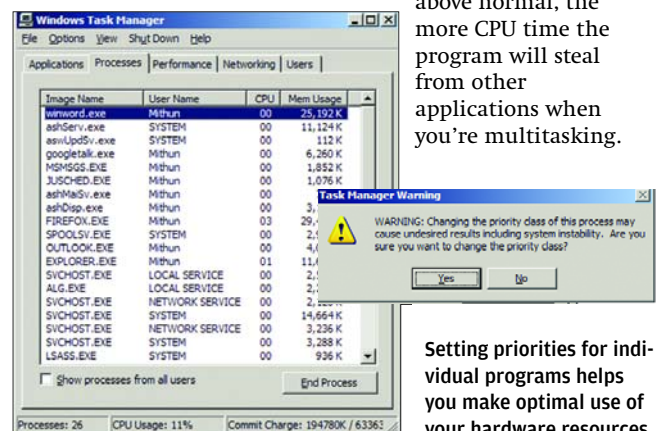
Priority is how the OS determines how to share processor time among applications. Most applications default to normal priority, so by setting your high-demand applications to a higher priority, you can increase its performance when multitasking.

To do this, load the program you wish to change the priority for, and press [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [Del] to bring up the Task Manager. Select the 'Applications' tab and highlight your program. Right-click the program and select 'Go to process.'

Now right-click on the highlighted process, and choose 'Set priority'. The higher you set the priority above normal, the more CPU time the program will steal from other applications when you're multitasking.



Just delete the screensavers you don't want



Setting priorities for individual programs helps you make optimal use of your hardware resources